Christian Salesmanship

CHIBOMBA FM

INTRODUCTION

At a meeting held in Dorchester, Massachusetts, November, 1848, I had been given a view of the proclamation of the sealing message, and of the duty of the brethren to publish the light that was shining upon our pathway. After coming out of vision, I said to my husband: "I have a message for you. You must begin to print a little paper and send it out to the people. Let it be small at first; but as the people read, they will send you means with which to print, and it will be a success from the first. From this small beginning it was shown to me to be like streams of light that went clear round the world." - *Life Sketches, 125 (1915).*

The book work should be the means of quickly giving the sacred light of present truth to the world. The publications that come forth from our presses today are to be of such a character as to strengthen every pin and pillar of the faith that was established by the word of God and by the revelations of His Spirit. Those who engage in the canvassing work should first give themselves wholly and unreservedly to God. Christ has invited them, "Come unto Me, all ye that labor and are heavy-laden, and I will give you rest. Take My yoke upon you, and learn of Me; for I am meek and lowly in heart: and ye shall find rest unto your souls. For My yoke is easy, and My burden is light." - *Manuscript 26, 1901.*

No Seventh-day Adventist who has gone from home to home as a colporteur can forget the many and varied receptions he/she has experienced. At times it would seem the gates of heaven were opened before him, and at other times a formidable "iron curtain" faced him. Success in gospel salesmanship not only demands consecration and spiritual power but the colporteur must also be a keen student of human nature, one who wins the confidence of his prospective purchasers.

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DEFINITION OF TERMS

- **Sale** - is the transfer of title or ownership of property, goods, service or idea from one person to another for a price.
- **Salesman (Canvasser)** - is the person who brings about the above mentioned transfer.
- **Salesmanship** - is the ability to convince or persuade people to buy or barter goods, property, idea or service according to what will best suit their needs.
- **Prospect** - a potential customer
- **Product** - a service or an item offered for sale
- **Market** - a means by which the exchange of products and services takes place as a result of prospects and salesmen being in contact with one another

Salesmanship can be defined as the ability of a person to sell a product or service to a customer by removing their ignorance and doubtfulness about the product in such a way that both the buyer as well as the seller gets to benefit from the deal. It also includes the ability to generate a need for the product and to make customers want the product.

To persuade a prospect to buy a product, the salesman must provide all product-related information and convince customers how the product can fulfill their requirements. It is not as easy as it seems, because, in the present times, a salesperson is required to interact with different people.

Therefore, knowing the product alone is not sufficient for a salesperson. He/she has to deal with different customers differently, which requires a plethora of skills. For example, sometimes, a salesperson is needed to act as a friend with one prospect and as a human-computer with another prospect.

A salesperson acts differently with different people. He is needed to display distinct personalities while interacting with different customers.

In the present times, the concept of salesmanship has even become broad as more and more transactions are taking place on the internet. The sellers are not required to interact with their customers face to face. But that does not mean that you don't need selling skills while selling your products through online platforms. You are still required to have excellent persuasive skills to sell your products.

Salesmanship is leadership

What this means is that the key to effective selling is to help customers think of you as more than just a *provider.* They don't just want someone they can *buy* from, but someone they can *follow.* They are looking for someone they can trust to lead them.

QUALITIES OF A CHRISTIAN SALESPERSON

1. **Personality** - A good salesman should possess a good personality. What fragrance is to a flower is personality to an individual. It is the ability to impress others. A charming personality always creates a good impression. He should possess good health, attractive appearance and impressive voice.
2. **Cheerful Disposition** – He/she should have a smiling face. It is rightly said that, "A man without a smiling face must not open a shop." In order to impress upon the prospects, a salesperson should always be cheerful and sweet tempered. He should be properly dressed as the dress greatly enhances the personality.
3. **Mental Ingredients** - An individual cannot be a successful salesman unless he possesses certain mental qualities like imagination, sound judgment, presence of mind, foresightedness, initiative and strong memory. These qualities are of great help to a salesman in dealing with customers having different nature and temperaments. The mental qualities are very helpful in creating permanent customers for the product.
4. **Courtesy** - A salesman should always be polite and courteous towards his customers. It costs nothing but wins permanent customers for the product. He should help the customers in making the right choice or in selecting the products. This will definitely help in winning over the confidence of the customers.
5. **Patience and Perseverance** - A salesman comes across different type of prospects. Some of them purchase nothing but waste time by asking irrelevant questions about the products. Under such circumstances, he should not loose temper but give patient hearing to them. He should try time and again to convince the customers. Customer is vital for him and he should not leave any stone unturned to give full satisfaction to the customers.
6. **Complete knowledge about the Self, Product, Company and the Prospect** - A salesman should clearly know about himself. He should try to find out his limitations and make constant efforts to overcome them. At the same time, he should know his strong points. While dealing with the prospects, he should exhibit his plus points and avoid displaying the weaknesses. He can remove his weaknesses by undergoing proper training. There is no denying the fact that salesmen are made and not born.
   He should possess the full knowledge about the product so that he may properly answer the questions of the prospects at the time of sale. The buyer depends to a great extent on the salesman especially in case of a new product.
   He should know about the design, colour, contents, materials used, labour employed and production technique etc. He should be conversant with the distribution channels employed to sell the product.
   He should also have full knowledge about the prospect (customer). The success of a salesman lies in creating permanent customer for the product. He should try to understand the nature, buying habits and motives of the customers. He should properly assess the requirements of the customers and should be capable of tackling the customers having different nature. He should show decent behaviour to the prospects.

RESPONSIBILITIES OF A CHRISTIAN SALESPERSON

- When dealing with customers, a Christian is honest and forthright.
- A Christian does not withhold information or misleading people simply to gain a sale.
- A Christian is not high pressure and will not try to intimidate people into purchasing a service or product from them.
- A Christian is empathetic and understanding of the customer's concerns and needs.
- A Christian knows his/her product and its benefits thoroughly and is able to answer questions competently and quickly in order to help his/her customer make the decision that will best serve him.
- A Christian is courteous to his employer, and remembers that it is his place to serve.
- A Christian will not cause strife in the work place and show angst toward his employer when talking with fellow employees or customers.
- A Christian will strive to put the best interest of the company at the forefront of his efforts by being professional and clean.
- A Christian will discuss problems with the source and not spread rumors in the work place.

TYPES OF SELLING APPROACHES

Inappropriate Selling Practices:

- The Flatterer - keeps on flattering the prospect.
- The Liar - promises fantastic guarantees which are not so.
- The Beggar - uses begging as the way to selling.
- The Briber - promotes kickback, representation expenses, etc.
- The Intimidator - uses threat to intimidate the prospect.
- The Peddler like a "walking store," bringing all items, allows the prospect to choose the item he prefers to buy.
- The Order-filler - gives the prospect only what he asks for.
- The Unethical - exhibits unethical behavior to make a sale.
- High Pressure - uses force in selling.

Christian and Professional Salesmanship:

Professional salesmanship is a Christian and professional way of conducting work. It is primarily concerned with the satisfaction of the costumer's needs. He/she diagnoses the need of the prospect and presents his products accordingly and convincingly.

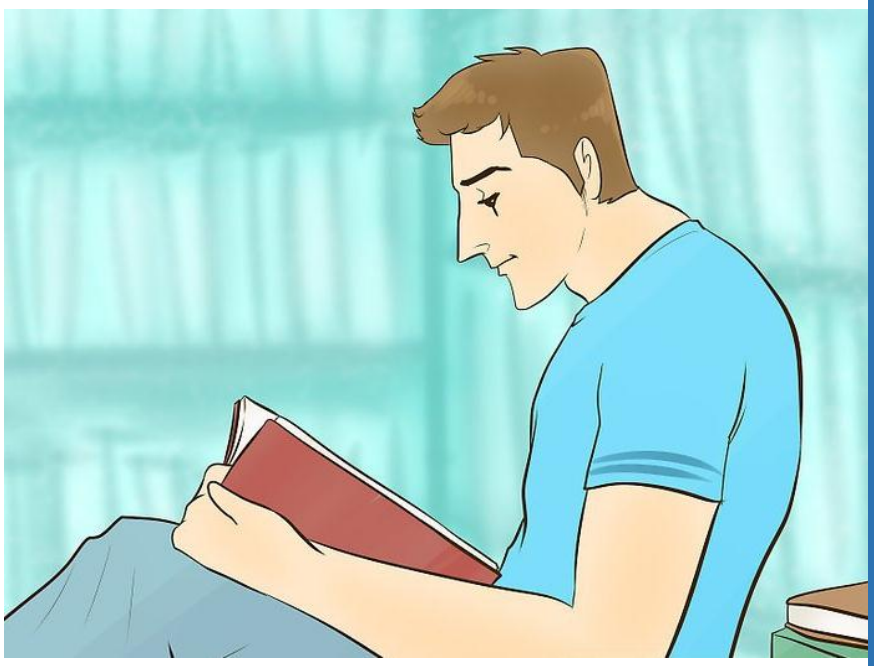
A Christian or Professional Salesman must choose only selling practices which are in accordance with Christian principles. "Canvassers need to be daily converted to God, that their words and deeds may be a savor of life unto life, that they may exert a saving influence" (CM, p. 48).

PHASES OF SALES PROCESS

1. **Pre-Sales Preparation** - The Salesperson does his/her preparation before going out to work.

2. **Proper-Sales Interview** - The Salesperson does his/her actual sales presentation in the presence of the prospect.
3. **Post-Sales Evaluation** - Accomplished after sale is consummated.

Pre-Sales Preparation



- A Christian Salesperson must prepare spiritually, as he/she is the ministry of leading men and women to Jesus Christ. He/she needs to needs to be obedient to heavenly principles (tithe, offerings and others), study the Bible and Spirit of Prophecy regularly.
- He/she needs to prepare mentally. He must possess knowledge of the Facts; know the number of pages, pictures, editions, languages, chapters and articles, type of binding, author & etc.
- He/she must have knowledge of the benefits - Identify the benefits provided by each book/literature he/she sells.
- Above all, a Salesperson must memorize a "Standard Sales Talk." This provides the best approach and selling points used and proven effective by most successful Salesmen. It provides concise yet accurate facts and benefits about the seller's books and magazines. It eliminates repetition and saves time for both the salesman and the prospect. It guarantees effective sales presentation by having the sales points arranged in a logical sequence.
- Ensure canvassing tools are well illustrated prospectus and presentable. Book samples must be clean, contract forms and receipts must be available all the time.

Steps of Proper Sales Interview

- A – ATTENTION: Approach, Bridging to the Heart, and Bridging to the Mind
- I – INTEREST: Creating the Need, and Product Presentation
- D – DESIRE: Handling Objections, and Closing the Sale
- A – ACTION: Issuing Sales Contract

ATTENTION

Pre-Approach

This begins the moment the prospect sees you. So, it is important to conduct yourself or act impressively even before you see the prospect. Have proper attire and physical appearance, exhibit a positive attitude, and walk briskly.

Pick the right time to go selling. During the work week, most people are at home and willing to answer their door between the hours of 5:00 and 7:00 pm. You may get people at home during traditional 9:00 am to 5:00 pm work hours, but not as many. Early in the morning is not good, as many people up and about are looking to go to work, not listen to a sales pitch.

Knock on the door or ring the doorbell. Step away from the door after knocking. It's less intimidating and respects personal space.

Approach Proper

This is accomplished when the Salesman and the prospect meet each other, usually at the door. It is important to do this properly in order to gain entrance into the home. As the door opens, greet him/her and introduce yourself.

Example: "Good morning, Mrs. _____? I am _____ of the Libala Adventist Youth Ministries. My visit is in the interest of your children, Mary and John. May I step in as I explain briefly? Thank you!" This treats each person as an individual rather than just a potential customer. You want the person to trust you and want to talk to you.

Bridging to the Heart

This is a process of creating and building the confidence of the prospect. Establish good rapport and win the prospect's confidence through respect, courtesy, and friendliness. Be enthusiastic; enthusiasm is contagious. Know your prospect, together with the family members, mention favorable comments about them which you learned through "advance information" from previous customer. Talk to the prospect about his interest or about things which he/she loves.

Bridging to the Mind

This is designed to alert the customer's mind as you begin creating the needs.

1. Share your thoughts through '**Statement of Concern**' with honest and sincere interest in helping people cope with present and potential problems which is the main objective of your visit.

   Example: "Mrs. Banda, there is a growing concern among parents today regarding the influence of the secular society upon our children. Drug abuse, television, and destructive literature, especially pornography, are taking their tool upon the youth of our country. Parents are asking what they can do to alleviate this matter."

2. Share your thoughts by mentioning current events, showing newspaper clippings and mentioning news from radio and TV.

   Example: "Mrs. Mubita, in these newspaper clippings that I gathered some time ago, there is a story of a mother who gave birth to a baby having two heads coming out from one body. The newspaper said that the mother had been smoking and taking drugs during her pregnancy."

3. Share your thoughts by use of **'startling facts'**.

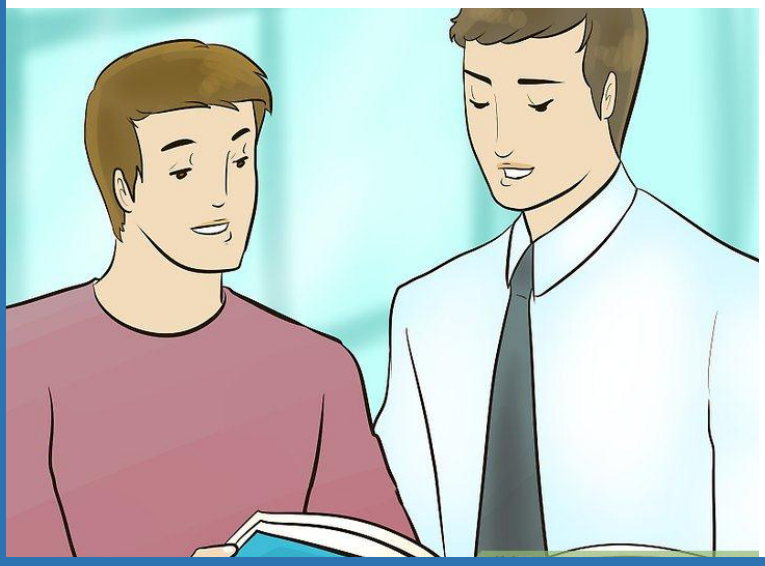
   Example: "Mr. Mwewa do you know that 56% of all deaths are the result of heart diseases?"

INTEREST

Creating the Need (Problem)
Most people are not aware of potential problems that may occur to them personally or their family. It is the responsibility of the Salesman to identify and create the problem-need of the prospect in his conscious mind.

Use a well-arranged pictorial prospectus and newspaper clippings to accomplish the following:

1. For Character Building Books - Show the evidences of increasing juvenile delinquency, the dangers of using drugs and the evil effects of destructive literature and television.
2. For Spiritual Books - Point serious present world condition.
3. For Medical Books - Explain the increasing number of illnesses and the excessive costs of medical treatments.



Product Presentation (solution)
The presentation of the books must be focused on how they will meet the needs already created in the mind of the prospect. They must provide solutions to the "Problem – need."

Know your product well. You need to be sure you know everything there is to know about what it is you are trying to display, and answer any and all questions that your potential customers have. This will allow

you to explain the product on a personal level. You don't want to dive right into the bullet points. Instead, let your customer know how this will benefit their life.

Be honest about what your product can and cannot do. You won't always have a good answer to a customer's question, but don't make promises your product can't keep. Instead, try to turn the conversation back towards your product's strengths.

Pay attention your customer. Pick up hints in tone and body language that indicate interest in you or your product. Interested people tend to maintain eye contact, lean forward, or tilt their head when you talk. Give them a chance to talk, ask questions, or offer suggestions about how they might be interested in using your product. If the conversation starts to drag, move on to discussing the product. If the customer is not showing any signs of interest, thank them for their time, and move on to the next door.

Keep an eye out for negative body language as well. Crossed arms or eyes looking elsewhere indicate the person is not interested, or is trying to keep you at a distance.

Demonstrate the product. If a person seems interested, but not yet willing to buy, offer to show them the product and how it works. If the person at the door expresses interest, say, "let me show you," rather than, "can I" or "may I." Those phrases open a window for the person to say no. It also looks pushy, like you are trying to force your way into someone else's house.

Trust your product to work. Don't offer excuses before you show what it does or can do. You need to demonstrate that what you are selling is quality and worthwhile.

Showing your product also gives the customer a chance to think about how it might be useful to them. Encourage them to describe their needs, and answer any questions.

DESIRE

<u>Handling Objections</u>

Objection is a reason or an excuse given by the prospect for not buying or delaying his/her decision to purchase. There are three (3) main types:

1. **Valid objections** may be caused by reasonable circumstances, like time element and emergencies.
2. **Pretense objections** may arise based on pretentious reasons by the prospect.
3. **Self-Generated Objections** are caused by the poor performance of the salesman.

- Objections may arise at the door when the Salesperson is slow in establishing a friendly contact.
- Objections can arise if the prospect had a bad experience in the past and is prejudice to any salesman.
- Objections may occur during a sales presentation, when the prospect has no interest and doesn't see the benefits.

- Objections may arise if you fail to prepare the mind of the prospect by showing statistics or reports that will make them aware of their needs.

How to Handle Objections:

Learn the common negative responses. Chances are that after going to a bunch of houses, you will hear certain similarities in disinterest. Keep an eye out for these basic themes, and prepare answers. You may not always get past them, but you will be prepared to address some early concerns.

A negative buyer can still be open to persuasion. Don't see those negative responses as refusals, but as opportunities to give more information.

Focus on your product's benefits. Your potential customer needs to know that what you are selling will give them something they want. You should know the difference between a "benefit" and a "feature." A feature is something your product does, such as a vacuum that picks up more dirt than its competitors. A benefit is what you get from that feature. For that vacuum, the benefit would be a cleaner, healthier home.

Be positive about your product. If your potential customer seems unwilling to buy, let your enthusiasm guide them. If they can't believe that you like or believe in your product, why should they?

Offer to provide more information. Most people will not want to stand in their doorway for too long, so if there is an opportunity to talk further, they will generally invite you inside. If possible, try to get contact information. With that, you can always offer to come back or call at another time. If you have fliers, business cards, or other printed materials with your contact information, this is a good moment to pass them out. If you don't have any, it might be good to get some.

Pay attention to clear rejections. If a person gives you a direct "No" in response to your offers, thank them for their time and move on to the next house. There is no benefit to pushing that person any further.

Closing the Sale

Do not close too early before the prospect understands the benefits of your product. But also learn to buy signals; once you are sure that your prospect has understood the benefits, cut your presentation to save on time and prevent possible 'Valid objections'.

Some of the signals from the prospect that they have understood and are interested in your product include: raising of eyebrows, giving a nod, looking at the contract receipt, getting the book from you for personal examination, asking for the price, asking you about delivery time, or giving you other verbal indications of interest.

How to close the sale

Summarize the benefits of your books or literature in order to exalt the value and to minimize the price.

Always have a positive attitude that the prospect will buy.

ACTION

Sales Contract

After the contract for the order has been completed and signed:

- On cash basis, this process is quick and simple. All you need to do is to issue the sales invoice.
- On order basis, this process is common. A salesperson has to request for a down payment or a deposit. This is to make the order contract more binding, and to make it easier for the prospect to pay upon delivery.

Commend the prospect for the good decision he/she made to buy. Re-assure them about the benefits of the book.

Post-Sales Evaluation

When home at night, it is beneficial to review your sales presentations done during the day. Review your target goals, analyze where you have succeeded, where you have failed, and the possible reasons for failure.

Study possible solutions and how to handle them efficiently next time. Endeavor to constantly improve your techniques.